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Research proposal

Astral customer discovery
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Research proposal



Why the work is needed 04–06

Our goals 08–09

What we propose 11–18

What we are asking for 19

Consent and data 20

Risks 21

Why the work is needed

Why the work is needed

We want to run a research-led discovery with IMSERV customers. Today we are designing Astral without evidence of how customers actually do their energy-data work.

Where this stands

Clive has offered to help unlock customer access. He has **not** agreed a research plan, scope, or sample size. This proposal is for that conversation.

The research repository has no studies, insights, archetypes, or experience scores yet.

What we risk without it

Designing for assumptions that have not been tested with customers, such as which working hats exist, what reporting means, and whether problems sit in the interface or in the service behind it.

NOT A FINDING YET

Everything here is a proposed approach. None of it is a finding about IMSERV customers yet.

What we already know

Every item has a source and a limit. Most of it is an internal account of customer behaviour, not observed with customers.

Evidence	Source	Limit
Clive and Emily Haddon did a dozen or more customer interviews. The notes sit with Clive	Work Desk notes, 4 Sep 2026	We have not seen the notes. We do not know who was interviewed or what was asked
British Gas and Scottish Water asked to take part in the beta	Work Desk notes, 4 Sep 2026	A route to customers. Not a sample
Customers want to see their own estate, know meters are working, get invoices and reports, and follow problems. Export is more common than looking at graphs	Max Lake, DataVision walk, 4 Sep 2026	Internal account of customer behaviour. Not observed with customers
People pick sites and meters, compare them, then export a file. They do not browse the whole portfolio	Max Lake, 4 Sep 2026	As above
Company types are Customer, Broker / TPI, Supplier, and Platform admin. A Customer has Energy, Finance, Asset, and Data working hats	IMSERV customer base, desk research, 12 Sep 2026	Public-page desk research. Not a study
Access has three separate parts: what the company bought, the person's role, and which sites and documents they can see	Astral product model, 22 Sep 2026	From the handoff transcript. The role matrix is still open
Large customers narrow from the whole portfolio, to a region, to sites, to one MPAN. One customer has about 8,000 MPANs	As above	Named in a talk. Not observed

Assumed and not yet known

Beliefs we have not tested with customers, and the gaps that matter to the decision.

ASSUMED

- The Energy, Finance, Asset, and Data hats describe how people work. They are a useful recruitment start. They may not be four archetypes.
- Customers mostly use Astral for reporting. Reporting may mean pulling data that is finished somewhere else.
- The people a senior contact introduces us to are the people who do the day-to-day work.
- Problems people raise about the portal are interface problems. Some may be service, process, or data-quality problems.

UNKNOWN

- Who actually logs in today and who just receives a file.
- What starts the work, what people check before they trust a figure, and where the work leaves the portal.
- Who does the work, who approves it, and who receives the result.
- Which behaviour patterns recur across organisations and roles.
- How often those patterns happen across a wider set of customers.
- Where the journey breaks down, and whether the cause is the interface or the service behind it.

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Our goals

Our goals

The discovery should produce three things.

BEHAVIOURAL ARCHETYPES

How people actually work, what they need, and what changes the design.

CUSTOMER JOURNEYS

Evidence-backed. What happens today, including work outside Astral.

PRIORITISED UX DECISIONS

Each one traceable to evidence, and ready for the BA team to turn into stories.

Decisions it should inform

- Which customer tasks and journeys Astral should prioritise for version one and after.
- Which behavioural differences need different designs, defaults, or trade-offs.
- Where problems sit in the service and process, not the interface. So we do not try to fix ownership or data quality with screen copy.
- What the BA team should specify next, with evidence behind each story.

Supporting questions

- What triggers the work, and what does finished look like?
- What do people check before they rely on a figure or share a report?
- Where does work leave Astral or DataVision, and why?
- Who contributes, approves, or acts, and what information do they need?
- Where does the work slow down, and what happens when it goes wrong?
- Which patterns recur across organisations, roles, and scales?

PRIMARY RESEARCH QUESTION

How do IMSERV customers do their energy-data work today, and which differences in that work should change how Astral is designed and prioritised?

Objectives

Six objectives. Each has a research question, the activity that answers it, the evidence, and a measure. Measures serve an objective. They are not collected for their own sake.

Objective	Research question	Activity	Evidence	Measure
1. Understand how customers do their energy-data work today, from trigger to finished outcome, including spreadsheets, email, and other tools.	What triggers the work, and what does finished look like?	Discovery interviews, walkthroughs	Episode accounts, artefacts	Journey stages covered per scenario
2. Identify recurring behavioural patterns that need different design priorities or trade-offs.	Which patterns recur across organisations, roles, and scales?	Interviews, analysis	Coded episodes across participants and organisations	Patterns observed in n of N participants and organisations
3. Understand what people check before they trust and share a figure or a report.	What do people check before relying on a figure?	Interviews, walkthroughs, survey	Described and shown checks. Reported frequency	Reported frequency among respondents
4. Identify who does, approves, and receives the work, and where handoffs and waiting happen.	Who contributes, approves, or acts?	Interviews, walkthroughs	Handoffs, correspondence	Handoffs per journey. Waiting points
5. Determine where problems come from the service, process, or data rather than the interface.	Where does it slow down, and why?	Walkthroughs, support evidence, blueprint	Breakdowns traced to cause	Problems classed interface, process, or data
6. Gauge how often the activities, checks, and problems we ask about happen across a wider group of respondents.	How often do these happen?	Survey	Responses	Share of respondents, by people and by organisation

Testing proposed design changes with customers is a possible follow-on study. It is not part of this proposal.

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What we propose

Review existing evidence → prepare → interview and survey side by side → analyse together → report with archetypes and journeys → present to the wider team.

Approach

A mixed-methods discovery. One round of interviews and a survey run at the same time, then are analysed together. The interviews show why. The survey shows how often.

Connected, not just collected

Both answer the same objectives. They are compared in one analysis, and disagreement is investigated, not smoothed away (Fetters, Curry and Creswell).

The trade-off: the survey cannot be built from interview findings, so it is built from what we already know and piloted first.

A **short screener** is still used for interview recruitment. That is different from the main survey.

Archetypes, not decorative personas

We will define research-backed behavioural profiles and customer journeys. The profiles do the job of personas, without fictional biographies.

Archetypes come from recurring patterns. They are not job titles with a new label.

Week 1: prepare

Ten stages in two phases. Agree the scope, then recruit and get ready for the interviews and the survey side by side.

STAGE 1

Agree scope and decisions

Confirm what the research must help decide, the priority journeys, the four user groups, and what is out of scope.

Days 1 and 2 of week 1

STAGE 2

Recruit for the interviews

Screen and book 12 people who do the work, 3 from each of four user groups, into the interview days in week 2.

Week 1 · See the interview plan

STAGE 3

Prepare the interviews

Finish the interview script, set up and test recording and transcription, and brief the notetaker.

Days 2 to 5 of week 1, alongside recruitment · See the interview plan

STAGE 4

Prepare the survey

Build the survey and its routing in SurveyMonkey or Microsoft Forms, pilot it with 2 or 3 target users, and write the invitation and reminder emails.

Days 2 to 4 of week 1 · See the survey plan

STAGE 5

Recruit for the survey

Agree who receives the survey and who sends it, and get the distribution list ready.

Days 3 to 5 of week 1 · See the survey plan

BEFORE WEEK 1

Already in place

Plan approved. Access coordinator named and introductions asked for. Privacy sign-off, including the survey tool. Existing notes shared.

Weeks 2 to 4: run, then report

Interviews in week 2 with the survey open alongside. Analysis in week 3. The report and presentation in week 4.

STAGE 6

Run the interviews

One round of 12 interviews. Notes are written up the same day. The last day of the week is kept for no-shows and reserves.

3 interview days in week 2, 4 a day. Day 5 for catch-ups · See the interview plan

STAGE 7

Run the survey

Send the invitation, then leave the survey open. One reminder, and a light check on responses.

Open for 8 working days, from the start of week 2 · See the survey plan

STAGE 8

Analyse the data

Code the interviews against the objectives, analyse the survey responses when it closes, and compare the two.

Week 3

STAGE 9

Write the report and UX deliverables

Write up the findings, with provisional behavioural archetypes, customer journey maps, and prioritised UX decisions.

Days 1 to 4 of week 4

STAGE 10

Present the findings

Present the findings and UX deliverables to the wider team, including the BA team.

1 session, on the last day of week 4

OVERALL

4 weeks

From the start of week 1 to presenting the findings, once the approvals and introductions are in place.

Testing proposed design changes with customers is a possible follow-on study. It is not part of this proposal.

Who we recruit

Twelve people, three from each of four user groups. What someone has done recently decides their group, not their job title. Proposed criteria, to agree at scoping.

3 INTERVIEWS

Energy managers

Energy, sustainability, or facilities managers responsible for one site or a portfolio.

INCLUDE IF, IN THE PAST THREE MONTHS, THEY HAVE

- Looked at energy use for their sites
- Investigated a spike, unusual reading, or missing data
- Compared sites, or reported progress against a target

AIM FOR A MIX OF

One site and multi-site portfolios. Regular and occasional users. More than one sector.

3 INTERVIEWS

Finance users

Finance managers, analysts, or accounts staff who handle energy costs and invoices.

INCLUDE IF, IN THE PAST THREE MONTHS, THEY HAVE

- Checked, queried, or approved an energy invoice
- Reported energy spend to someone else
- Looked for where costs could be cut

AIM FOR A MIX OF

People who prepare figures and people who approve them. Portal users and people sent files by others.

3 INTERVIEWS

Brokers / TPIs

Brokers, consultants, and third-party intermediaries who act for one or more customers.

INCLUDE IF, IN THE PAST THREE MONTHS, THEY HAVE

- Prepared a report or checked an invoice for a client
- Pulled energy data for a client
- Managed access for a client, or acted on their behalf

AIM FOR A MIX OF

Small and large client books. Independent and larger firms. More than one type of client.

3 INTERVIEWS

Data and asset users

Analysts, metering or asset staff, and people who feed IMSERV data into other systems.

INCLUDE IF, IN THE PAST THREE MONTHS, THEY HAVE

- Exported or received data for another process, by file or API
- Raised or followed up a meter fault
- Checked data was complete before using it

AIM FOR A MIX OF

File and API users. Data roles and asset or maintenance roles.

How we recruit

Clive and the access coordinator suggest people. A short screener confirms they do the work and places them in a group.

EVERYONE MUST

- Works for an IMSERV customer, or acts for one
- Has done at least one of their group's activities in the past three months
- Uses IMSERV data or outputs, directly or through someone else
- Can join a 60-minute remote session in week 2, and agrees to recording

WE EXCLUDE

- IMSERV staff standing in for customers
- People who designed the flows being discussed
- Senior contacts who do not do the work themselves, unless they approve it
- More than one person per group from the same organisation, where we can avoid it

PLACING PEOPLE

- Someone who fits two groups goes in the group for the activity they do most
- People who rely on someone else for IMSERV data still qualify. How they get it is part of what we learn
- Reserves are screened the same way, one or two across the groups

The screener

Question	What it tells us
Which organisation do you work for? Do you work for it directly, or act for it?	Customer or intermediary. Organisation coverage
In the past three months, which of these have you done with IMSERV data?	Group, and that they do the work
How often do you do the activity you do most?	Regular or occasional use
How do you usually get IMSERV data?	Portal, files from others, API, or a mix
About how many sites, or clients, does your work cover?	Scale and complexity
Is there anything that would help you take part?	Access needs and support
Which of these times in week 2 suit you?	Booking

THE SURVEY

Everyone in the reachable population who uses IMSERV data or outputs, across all four groups. No quotas. A1 and A2 sort respondents by what they do, and results are reported by group.

BALANCE WITHIN EACH GROUP

Activities, frequency, scale, working relationships, service experience, tools, and access needs. The interview plan sets these out.

What the research produces

Current state and future proposals stay visibly separate.

BEHAVIOURAL ARCHETYPES

- Recurring goals and situations
- Working strategies and information needs
- Constraints, handoffs, and difficulties
- Design implications
- Supporting evidence and known exceptions

We do not decide the number in advance.

CUSTOMER JOURNEYS

- Start with the current experience, including work outside Astral
- Go deep on two or three priority scenarios
- Actor, trigger, outcome, stages, handoffs, waiting, and exceptions
- A service blueprint for cross-department issues

PRIORITISED UX DECISIONS

- Each follows one chain, so it stays traceable into BA work
- Observation, interpretation, and recommendation stay separate

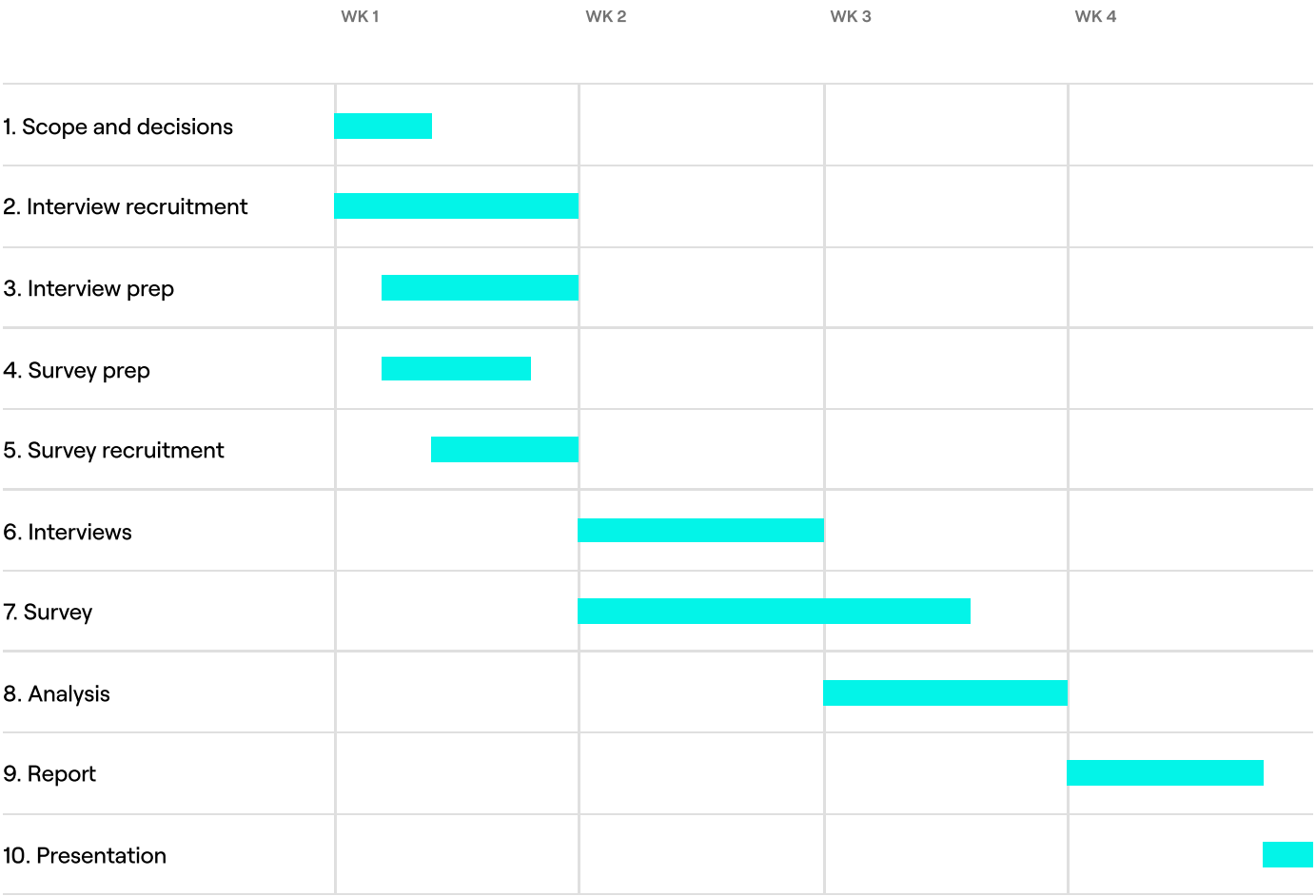
STEP 1 Evidence	STEP 2 User need	STEP 3 Journey problem
STEP 4 Design hypothesis	STEP 5 Story and acceptance criteria	STEP 6 Evaluation

THE TEST FOR EVERY ARCHETYPE

Would this profile change how we design, prioritise, or evaluate a real task?

Provisional timeline

A tight plan to agree, not a commitment. Four weeks from the start of week 1 to presenting the findings. It only works if the approvals and introductions are in place before week 1.



Before week 1

The four weeks start only when these are done.

- The plan is approved by the manager and Clive
- An access coordinator is named, and introductions to all four user groups are asked for
- The privacy owner has signed off consent, recording, transcription, storage, and the survey tool
- Clive and Emily's interview notes are shared
- Researcher and notetaker diaries are clear for week 2

Stages and dependencies

What each stage needs before it can start. Durations are provisional.

Stage	Provisional duration	Depends on
1. Agree scope and decisions	Days 1 and 2 of week 1	Time with Clive and the manager. Existing interview notes shared before week 1
2. Recruit for the interviews	Week 1	Access coordinator named, and introductions asked for before week 1
3. Prepare the interviews	Days 2 to 5 of week 1, alongside recruitment	Privacy sign-off for recording and transcription before week 1
4. Prepare the survey	Days 2 to 4 of week 1	An approved survey tool. Privacy sign-off before week 1
5. Recruit for the survey	Days 3 to 5 of week 1	Distribution route. Reachable population known
6. Run the interviews	3 interview days in week 2, 4 a day. Day 5 for catch-ups	Bookings. Tested recording
7. Run the survey	Open for 8 working days, from the start of week 2	Piloted survey. Distribution list
8. Analyse the data	Week 3	Transcripts. The survey closed by the middle of week 3
9. Write the report and UX deliverables	Days 1 to 4 of week 4	Analysis
10. Present the findings	1 session, on the last day of week 4	Report. Time with the wider team booked before week 1

What we are asking for

Seven things we need from reviewers before the research starts.

	Ask	Status
1	**Review this plan** and agree or change the scope, the decisions it supports, and the provisional timeline.	To agree
2	**Agree the first research decisions with Clive.** Which journeys matter most and what is out of scope.	To agree
3	**Name an access coordinator.** Someone who can introduce us to customers and book sessions.	To agree
4	**Access to the people who do the work.** Not only senior account contacts.	To agree
5	**Access to Clive and Emily Haddon's existing customer interview notes.** So we build on them, not repeat them.	To agree
6	**A privacy and data-protection owner.** To agree recording, transcription, storage, and any AI processing before the first session.	To agree
7	**An approved survey tool.** SurveyMonkey or Microsoft Forms, cleared for customer answers.	To agree

Working alongside the BA team

- Early themes from the interview days are shared with the BA team, marked provisional
- Stories link back to the need and evidence behind them
- The BA team (Claire and others) can add open story questions to the script before the interview days

The other two documents

- **Interview plan and script.** How the discovery interviews run, who takes part, and the script, with every question tied to an objective.
- **Survey plan and script.** How the survey is built, piloted, and analysed, and the draft questions with their routing, each tied to an objective.

Neutral draft. No consent wording is sent until it is approved. Legal review before it reaches a participant.

Consent, privacy and data

Agreed with IMSERV's privacy and data-protection owner before the first session.

Every session

- Informed consent for every participant before the session
- Recording, transcription, storage, retention, and any AI processing agreed with IMSERV's privacy and data-protection owner before the first session
- Approved storage with restricted access. Raw recordings and transcripts stay restricted
- Customer documents shown in walkthroughs are redacted or not kept, as agreed
- Participants are P01, P02 in analysis. Removing names alone may not anonymise a distinctive business account
- Quotes in shared outputs only with consent for anonymised quotation
- No consent wording is sent until it is approved. The current wording is a neutral draft

How AI is used

Copilot can help organise approved material, suggest candidate patterns, and keep evidence links up to date. Only within what the privacy owner approves.

It will **not** invent quotes, build archetypes from job titles, or treat simulated customers as evidence.

Risks and limits

What could weaken the evidence, and what we do about it.

Risk	Effect	Mitigation
Introductions only reach senior contacts	We hear about the work, not from the people doing it	Ask for practitioners by the activity they do. Track who does what in the screener
Participants come from one or two organisations	Shared local process looks like a pattern	Track organisation coverage. Recruit across several
Recruitment or privacy approval is slow	The timeline moves	Agree both before week 1. Hold one or two reserve participants
Four weeks leaves no slack	One late approval or several no-shows moves the whole plan	Start only when everything in Before week 1 is done. Keep day 5 of week 2 for catch-ups. Agree with the manager what can slip first
Analysis and reporting get a week each	Archetypes and journeys are less tested than they would be with more time	Present archetypes and journeys as provisional. Name what needs more evidence
The survey is open for only 8 working days	Fewer responses, mostly from engaged customers	Send it from a sender customers know. Send one reminder. Report respondents, not customers
The survey runs before the interviews can shape it	It measures our assumptions, or uses words customers do not	Build answer options from scoping and existing notes. Pilot with target users. Keep a “Something else” answer and read it
Four interviews a day, three days running, tires the researchers	Later sessions get thinner probing and notes	One moderator and one notetaker. Gaps between sessions. Write up notes the same day
Existing interview notes are not available	We repeat work, or miss context	Ask Clive early. Record what they cover
The survey reaches only engaged customers	Patterns look more common than they are	Report respondents, not customers. Name the sampling limits
Prototype screens steer discovery	We confirm our own design	No screens in this study. Test design changes in a follow-on study
Archetypes are expected before evidence exists	A persona deck without support	Agree upfront that archetypes emerge from the interviews and survey
Twelve interviews leave gaps in a multi-role audience	Three per group shows differences between groups, not everything about each group	Recruit across several organisations. Name the gaps in the report, and propose extra sessions where they matter



Thank You

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